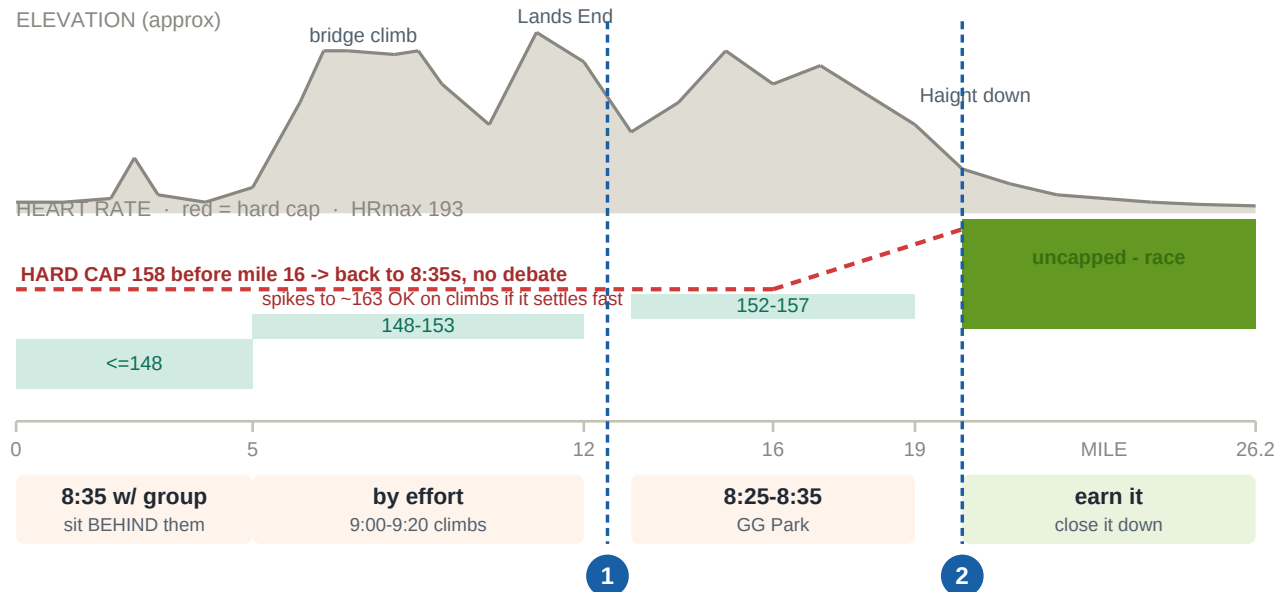


SF Marathon Race Plan

Sunday, July 26, 2026 · 5:00 AM start · HRmax 193 · green light confirmed 7/22

A goal 3:42–3:45	B goal 3:48–3:50	C goal strong finish, sub-4
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The one job on race morning: sit **BEHIND** the 3:45 pacer through mile 5. Fresh legs will beg to drift ahead — don't. The fast legs are for mile 20.



Pacing — start with the 3:45 pacer

Miles	Pace	HR	Notes
1–5 flat Embarcadero, Ft. Mason bump	with group (~8:35)	≤ 148	Embarrassingly easy. Good. Sit behind the pacer. First gel ~mile 4.
6–12 bridge, Marin turnaround, Sea Cliff	by effort — ignore clock	148–153 spikes to 160–163 OK	Recovery check: back under ~152 within 2–3 min of cresting. If pacer pushes a climb, let a gap open; close it on the descent. Short quick steps downhill (ITB).
12–13 — DECISION 1 entering GG Park			Pre-authorized (green light 7/22): default is drift to 8:20–8:25 — unless HR >153 settled, legs off, or fueling slipped. Do NOT surge to catch the 3:40 group.
13–19 GG Park, rolling	8:25–8:35	152–157	Should feel like miles 14–18 of the July 5 twenty-miler. Haight descent ~19–20: high cadence, no hammering.
20 — DECISION 2 flat from here			HR ≤158 and legs present → close at 8:10–8:20, HR uncapped. Otherwise hold 8:35s and protect 3:45.
20–26.2 Mission/Potrero, flat	whatever you've earned	free	Expected race average ~154–156 (~80%), finishing near 87%.

Fueling: 60–80 g carbs/hr — GU gel every 25–30 min from mile 3–4, washed down from the 415 ml flask. **Sodium (salty sweater): ~500–700 mg/hr** — one Liquid IV in the flask at start, second stick dry, added at a mid-race refill. Do NOT double-concentrate the bottle. Take gels 5–6 even when you don't feel like it — that reluctance at mile 19 is exactly when skipping one costs the race.

If the HR sensor dies mid-race

The plan is HR-gated, so have a fallback. Pace the first half by the 3:45 group + the **talk test**: you should be able to speak full conversational sentences through mile 13. Decision 1 becomes "is breathing still easy / nose-able?" instead of $HR \leq 153$. Abandon the aggressive branch if breathing turns hard-rhythmic before mile 16. You know the course and your effort — the plan works without the watch.

Race morning (5 AM start — compressed)

- **Night before:** carb-heavy early dinner (~6–7 PM) + pre-bed snack ~9 PM (toast + honey, banana). Lay out kit. Early to bed — shift bedtime earlier all week.
- **Wake ~3:15–3:30** and eat immediately: small ~60–80 g liquid-leaning breakfast (half bagel + banana + sports drink / Maurten 160). Coffee if habitual.
- **Kit:** Endorphin Pros, HR strap snug + watch restarted, flask w/ 1 Liquid IV, 2nd stick dry, gels (alternate flavors), runner's-loop laces.
- **10–15 min before gun:** gel. Then find the 3:45 sign and start the day behind it.

Last days

Thu 7/24 — easy 3 + 4 strides; start carb-loading (8–10 g/kg/day, low fiber, salt generously)

Fri 7/25 — rest or 15-min shakeout; carb-heavy early dinner + 9 PM snack; early night

Sat... Sun 7/26 — RACE. Wake ~3:15–3:30, small breakfast 90 min out, exactly as practiced.

Rules that override everything

- **Knee/ITB:** any twinge → shorten stride, high cadence, ease off. It's been quiet 7 weeks; keep it that way.
- The nerves are readiness with nowhere to go yet. Every fitness marker is at an all-time high. Trust the July 5 twenty-miler — you've already run the hard version of this.
- Nothing new on race day. The plan is done. Your only job is to execute miles 1–5 patiently; the rest unfolds one pre-made decision at a time.